

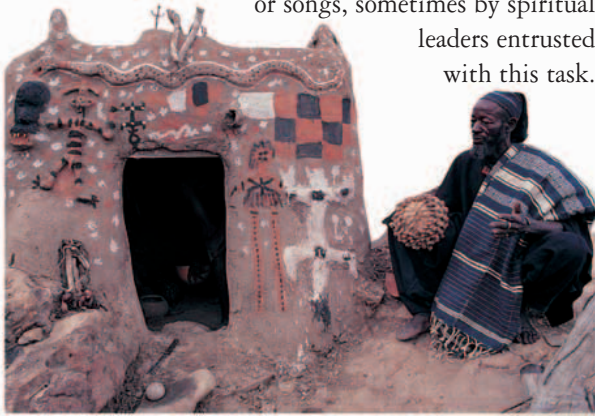


A rich culture

Beautiful African artifacts including fabrics, sculptures, masks, baskets, and jewelry have long been the envy of visitors to the continent. African myths and religious beliefs are less accessible to foreigners, but are no less powerful and compelling.

ORAL TRADITION

Writing is rare in African cultures. Important ritual and cultural information is communicated through art or songs, sometimes by spiritual leaders entrusted with this task.



COUNTRY LIFE

Many Africans live by cultivating land or raising animals. Some farmers produce enough food for themselves and maybe a little to sell locally; others work for big farms producing large amounts of cash crops like cocoa, coffee, or bananas for sale abroad.

CRAFTWORK

Somali women weave baskets, which are both functional and beautiful. These qualities are the hallmarks of African craftwork traditions.



MASKS AND RITUALS

In some religious ceremonies, participants don fantastic masks or costumes and allow themselves to be possessed by a spirit or god.



MUSIC AND DANCING

African music and dance often serves a ceremonial purpose. Here, South African women celebrate Nelson Mandela's presidential campaign.



Many rural Africans today live in huts something like this one.

